

The Growing Fascination

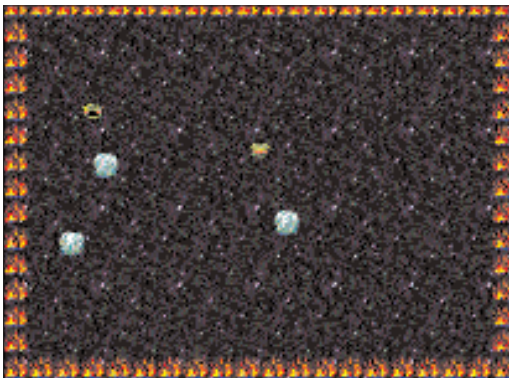
It all started during a computer class at school—Sri Kumaran Children's Home. The teachers introduced the class to making games using a tool called Game Maker (and you thought schools only taught boring stuff like programming), and Shashank was hooked. He started experimenting with the program himself, soon leading to his first game—*Burger in The Oven*. The game itself is quite basic—just click on the burgers that bounce all over the screen, but even with that simple task, it's horribly addictive. Of course, Shashank knows this. On his Web site (www.shashankhrgames.com), you will find this cautionary note: "Careful while playing my games, they are addictive."

The next game was *Man and Monster*—a three-level adventure, which was the first step to his latest—*Go Tomatoes!*, and last month, he finished *Go Tomatoes!*, a game he'd been working on for the past couple of months.

So why does he keep making these games? "I just do it as a hobby. It's really fun, you know," he says. And his intentions are quite noble too—he does it for a greater good: "I almost never play my games" he says, "but my friends enjoy them."

The Game

Remember the classic platform games like *Dangerous Dave*? Well, that was the first thing we thought of when we played *Go Tomatoes!* for the first time. It's a simple 2D game, where you

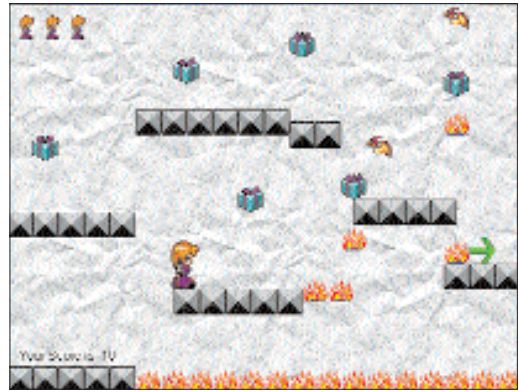


The one that started it all—*Burger in The Oven*



"I almost never play my games, but my friends enjoy them"

Shashank H R
Student
Bangalore



Man and Monster—something's brewing here



And presenting... *Go Tomatoes!*

go around the room collecting tomatoes. And here's an interesting element of realism: ripe tomatoes are the best, giving you a juicy score, the overripe ones are worth a little less, and the rotten tomatoes are the worst—not only do they subtract from your score, they also cost you your health, eventually causing you to die if you eat too many.

There are six levels of tomato-munching fun, and our only complaint with the game is that it's too short!

What Next?

Even as you read this, Shashank has started learning how to create his own 3D game—something we're all waiting eagerly for. So if you've created 3D games of your own and have some useful advice for him, pop over to his Web site and contact him.

Ask him if he wants to become a serious game developer when he grows up, and he mulls, "It's still too early to decide. I like doing this, but it's just a hobby right now". For the good of Indian game development, we sure hope he doesn't stop liking it in the years to come.

Well, we've had our unofficial "Youngest Reader" competitions, and now Shashank has kicked off the "Youngest Doer-of-something-cool-and-geeky" competition. So if you know someone whose techie activity deserves a mention in *Digit*, drop us a line—the younger the better! ■

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Game Maker

Game Maker (www.gamemaker.nl) is a free game creation tool that doesn't need you to have any programming knowledge—just enough creativity to figure out what your game should be. It's excellent for 2D games like clones of our favourites—Mario, PacMan, Arkanoid, you name it. You can add backgrounds, sound effects, animations, background music, and loads more with the free version. It lets you create your own 3D games as well! It comes packed with a bunch of free images and animations, so you don't even need

to make the graphics for your first game. Once you've created a game, you own all the rights to it, so do with it as you will—distribute it among your friends, or send it to us; if it's good, we'll even put it on our CD!

You can find plenty of game tutorials on Game Maker's Web site, as well as games that were created using Game Maker.

We've included Game Maker on this month's CD, and to learn how to create your first *Arkanoid* clone in thirty minutes, turn to page xx in this issue.